

BACKGROUND UNWOMEN

Introduction

"Sexual Violence as Method of Warfare: Addressing the Systematic Use of Forced Sexual Intercourse as a Political and Military Weapon"

Welcome, delegates to the United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women in the 16th edition of the Model United Nations, Instituto Oriente, 2026. It is a great pleasure for us, your chair, to guide you in this model.

We, as a Chair, are excited and grateful for having you in this committee. This chair aspires that each delegate has a good experience. Remember that your ideas and your proposals matter. We, as Chair, truly believe that each of you will give your best. This is a huge opportunity to develop your skills and be able to participate memorably, keeping in mind that we must trust ourselves to achieve a good result.

It is important to be informed about Sexual Violence as a Method of Warfare: Addressing the Systematic use of Forced Sexual Intercourse as a Political and Military weapon, since this affects people worldwide during armed conflicts, leaving numerous consequences, both psychological and physical, such as humiliating the enemy, reinforcing hierarchies, and demoralizing. Physical consequences are: Genital injuries, sexually transmitted diseases, and forced pregnancies. These attacks have political, military, or strategic purposes; they are not random acts, but deliberate tactics used by armed forces and armies.

This conflict has no exact origin, but it has been documented since ancient times. In ancient Rome and Greece, soldiers often forced sexual relations as part of the "spoils of armed conflict." In the 1990s, in conflicts such as Rwanda and Bosnia, this violence was legally recognized for the first time as a crime against humanity.

We, as a Chair, chose this topic because it is one of the cruelest and most silenced forms of violence in armed conflict. Despite its devastating impact, it continues to be minimized in many international contexts. We want to give a voice to the victims, denounce the use of the human body as a battlefield, and promote justice and memory.

Choosing this topic is an act of social responsibility. It brings to light a crime that has destroyed entire lives and that, despite being considered a crime of armed conflict, often goes unpunished.
In this document, we will provide you with the necessary tools to conduct a participatory debate, thus creating delegates capable of expressing their opinions. We, as a Chair, will address controversial points that will be useful throughout the model. We, as Chair, sincerely appreciate your commitment and willingness to address such a complex and sensitive issue.



History of the Committee

UN WOMEN is the United Nations agency mandated to promote gender equality and the empowerment of women. It acts as a global advocate for the rights of women and girls and was established to accelerate progress in improving their living conditions, as well as respond to their needs.

This organization works with UN Member States to set international standards focused on achieving gender equality. It encourages equal participation of women in all aspects of life and collaborates with governments and civil society to develop laws, policies, and programs that ensure these rules are effectively applied, always aiming to bring real and positive outcomes for women and girls.

UN WOMEN focuses primarily on five key areas:

- Promoting women's leadership and participation.
- Including women in all peace and security processes.
- Eradicating violence against women.
- Strengthening women's economic autonomy.
- Integrating gender equality into national development planning and budgeting.

In addition, UN Women works to achieve a more inclusive world with gender equality as a fundamental part of the Sustainable Development Goals, leading the work of the United Nations system in support of gender equality in the debates and agreements related to the 2030 Agenda.

Presence in history

Throughout the years, the United Nations has faced different challenges in its struggle for the support and promotion of gender equality in the world. Among these challenges, inadequate funding and the absence of any element of impetus that would guide the activities of
The United Nations in related disputes.



In July 2010, the United Nations General Assembly created the United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women (UN Women) to address these issues. UN Member States took a significant step forward to speed up progress in promoting gender equality and empowering women. As part of the UN's reform efforts, UN WOMEN was created to bring together different mandates and resources, making the organization's work more effective.

UN Women builds on the work of four key organizations that were already separate from the main United Nations system. Each of these organizations shared the goal of promoting gender equality and women's empowerment. These organizations were: the Division for the Advancement of Women (DAW), the International Research and Training Institute for the Advancement of Women (INSTRAW), the Office of the Special Adviser on Gender Issues and the Advancement of Women (OSAGI), and the United Nations Development Fund for Women (UNIFEM).

Long Term

International Context

Between 2005 and 2015, the international community began to recognize that sexual violence in armed conflicts was far more than an unfortunate consequence of war. It became clear that such acts were deliberate strategies used to create fear, humiliate communities, forcibly displace populations, and break social structures.

In 2008, the United Nations Security Council adopted Resolution 1820, establishing a significant shift. This resolution accepted that sexual violence in armed conflicts can be a heinous conflict crime, a crime against humanity, or even genocide.

Based on this resolution, UN peacekeeping missions were strengthened with clearer tasks to specifically protect women and girls from sexual violence in conflict zones. Additionally, the UN began issuing annual reports to monitor the situation and promote responsibility for these acts.

State-Legalized or Tolerated Violence

In many countries affected by armed conflict, sexual violence was ignored, minimized, or even justified by governments and armed groups. There were no effective laws to protect victims, and perpetrators were rarely held accountable.

In places like the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Sudan, and South Sudan, sexual violence was used as a tool of punishment and territorial control. Despite efforts by institutions like the International Criminal Court, impunity prevailed, and victims faced corrupt or non-existent justice systems.

Social Movements and Survivors' Voices



Despite attempts to silence them, victims began speaking

out. Dr. Denis Mukwege, a Congolese doctor, has treated thousands of women survivors of sexual violence at Panzi Hospital since 1999. His work gained international recognition, earning him the Sakharov Prize (2014) and the Nobel Peace Prize (2018).

In the Middle East, the Yazidi crisis shocked the world. Between 2014 and 2015, ISIS abducted and sexually enslaved thousands of Yazidi women and girls in Iraq and Syria. Nadia Murad, a survivor, escaped and testified, highlighting sexual violence as part of a genocidal campaign.

Organizations like UN Women, Amnesty International, and UNFPA launched awareness campaigns. In 2014, the Global Summit to End Sexual Violence in Conflict was held in London, gathering leaders from over 100 countries and establishing concrete commitments.

Political consequences

In the social sphere, victims are often rejected, creating family fractures and stigmatization. It also causes intergenerational trauma, causing psychological damage and affecting cultural transmission within communities. This persists throughout the victims' lives.



Social consequences

Addressing the political consequences, these include the weakening of the rule of law. Impunity reinforces citizen distrust of public institutions, thus hindering peace. These abuses complicate the negotiation of agreements and reconciliation processes.

Economic consequences

Economically speaking, there are countless consequences, making it a complex dilemma. One of these is the loss of productivity, as the labor force participation of those involved or victims is reduced, severely impacting the domestic and community economy. This dilemma also involves significant health and legal expenses, generating high costs for health care, psychological care, and legal systems to care for victims and thus achieve a fair sentence.

Short term

International Context

Sexual violence as a method of warfare is not a new phenomenon. However, in the last five years (2019-2024), various conflicts have shown that this tactic continues to be used as a political and military tool.

One legal action that has been implemented is Resolution 2467, created by the United Nations in 2019. This strengthens the fight against sexual violence, and mechanisms were created to monitor and report on these attacks in areas of armed conflict, such as the Team of Experts on the Rule of Law of the United Nations.

Although significant progress has been made in the legal, institutional, and humanitarian fields over the past five years, the international community still faces the challenge of converting the formal recognition of these crimes into effective justice, comprehensive reparation, and real prevention.

Political consequences

In recent years, sexual violence has been systematically used as a weapon of armed conflict in several conflicts. Beyond the harm to the victims, this practice has serious political consequences, weakens governments, hinders peace, and generates international sanctions.

In recent conflicts, sexual violence has been used as a military and political strategy. This has led to the delegitimization of the state, causing governments to lose national and international credibility. The states involved face economic sanctions, diplomatic restrictions, or even investigations for crimes of armed conflict. Governments use the suffering of victims to gain support or delegitimize their enemies.

Mass sexual violence can collapse judicial and public health systems, revealing the state's inability to protect its population.

Social consequences

Sexual violence in armed conflict not only causes irreparable individual harm but also has devastating effects on the social structures of the affected communities. When this violence is used systematically and for political or military purposes, it becomes a tactic to disintegrate communities and destroy their social bonds.

Among the social consequences are social and family isolation, school dropouts, and re-victimization. In the Tigray conflict, multiple United Nations reports documented the systematic use of sexual violence by Ethiopian government troops and allied forces. Women and girls were gang-raped and sexually enslaved as part of a strategy to demoralize the Tigray population and destroy the region's social fabric.



"They wanted us to get pregnant to change our ethnicity," one victim recounted in a 2021 report.

Economic consequences

Economically speaking, there are countless consequences, but we will address the most significant. Regarding the victims, survivors often face job loss, increased economic dependency, and direct and indirect medical care costs.

When sexual assaults sow terror in communities, they are forced to abandon their homes, crops, animals, and productive assets. In some contexts, prolonged displacement leads to the ruin of entire populations, who become dependent on humanitarian assistance.

The countries involved face sanctions imposed by the UN, the EU, the US, and other multilateral organizations, which affect foreign trade, investments, and access to financial or humanitarian aid. Companies also avoid investing in countries where serious human rights violations occur for fear of reputational, legal, or instability risks.

Topic and the United Nations

The United Nations has worked for years to protect people's rights in every country. They do this through agreements, programs, peace deals, resolutions, and guiding principles. The UN has different groups focused on specific issues to tackle problems better.

One important issue lately has been the use of sexual violence on purpose during armed conflicts. This breaks international law and hurts the dignity of people. It's often used as a way to scare communities, control them, and shake political systems during fighting.

Over time, different parts of the UN joined forces to better understand this problem, listen to survivors, and take real action. The Office of the Special Representative on sexual violence in armed conflicts, together with UN Women and other UN groups, leads the effort to stop these abuses, support survivors, and make sure those responsible are held accountable. Thanks to this teamwork, laws, reporting systems, and support programs exist—not just to bring justice but to help survivors heal and regain their dignity.

UN Resolutions and International Frameworks

A big step came in 2008 when the UN Security Council approved Resolution 1820. For the first time, it openly said that sexual violence in armed conflicts is not just random but a tactic to harm people and threaten peace. This resolution made clear that forced sexual intercourse and other forms of sexual violence are serious crimes, like war crimes, crimes against humanity, or genocide. Later, more resolutions helped improve how cases are tracked, justice is served, and survivors are supported.



Back in 2000, the Security Council also took an important step with Resolution 1325. It recognized that conflicts affect women and girls in unique ways and stressed how important their

active role is in peace processes. Since then, more resolutions have created a strong framework to protect women and girls during armed conflicts.

Another essential tool is the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court from 1998. It explains acts like forced sexual intercourse, sexual slavery, forced prostitution, forced pregnancy, and other forms of sexual violence as war crimes and crimes against humanity. Thanks to this statute, many political and military leaders have been brought to justice for these crimes committed during armed conflicts.

Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action (1995)

Back in 1995, leaders and activists from all over the world met in Beijing to talk about something that really mattered: the rights and safety of women. That meeting—known as the Fourth World Conference on Women—became a turning point. One of the most remarkable things that came out of it was a plan named the Beijing Declaration and Platform for Action. It talked about twelve important areas where women were still facing injustice, and one of them was the violence many of them go through, especially during armed conflict.

The document said something simple but strong: no woman or girl should ever have to live in fear or be hurt, no matter what is going on in their country. It also called on leaders around the world to stop looking the other way—and to actually do something to protect them.



That moment lit a spark. People everywhere started speaking up, organizing, and pushing for real change. And twenty years later, the promise made in Beijing was renewed. Countries stood up once again and said, "We're not done. We still believe in this. And we're going to keep working to stop sexual violence wherever it happens."

Strategic Programs and Complementary Actions

When violence shakes communities, women and girls often suffer in ways many don't see or understand. That's why the United Nations isn't

just talking—they're rolling up their sleeves and doing the hard work to make a real difference.

One of their strongest efforts is UN Action Against Sexual Violence in Conflict. This is a team of 21 UN groups all working side by side, making sure survivors are heard, cared for, and never left to face things alone. Their goal? To break the silence, bring those responsible to justice, and give survivors the support they need to heal—not just physically, but emotionally too.

The UN Women Strategic Plan for 2022–2025 is about more than just stopping violence—it's about assisting women and girls find their own power, building up the places that can feel protected, and making sure women have a real voice when peace is being created. Because peace isn't peace unless everyone's included.

When the pandemic hit in 2020, things got even harder. But UN Women didn't back down. They stood with over 590 women-led groups, the true heroes on the ground, helping communities survive and recover. Together, they reached over 100 million people, offering support that truly got what women and girls were going through.



All of this is part of a bigger dream—a world where women and girls can live with no fear, without violence, and with the respect and dignity they deserve. It's a promise to make equality a reality, and the plan is to get it by 2030.

At the end of the day, this is about women—about standing together, listening, and making sure nobody gets left behind.

Controversy points

Sexual violence used as a weapon in armed conflict represents one of the most brutal and systematic expressions of violence. Far from being mere "collateral damage" or an isolated act committed by soldiers, it has been widely documented that in many conflict contexts, the use of forced sexual relations has been a deliberate strategy of domination and ethnic cleansing.

Why is it a controversial topic?

The controversy revolves around several aspects. For a long time, sexual violence in armed conflict was minimized or ignored by governments, international organizations, and even courts of law. It was considered an inevitable consequence of the chaos of armed conflicts, not a planned tactic. Only in recent decades, following mass crimes in Rwanda, Bosnia, and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, has it begun to be formally recognized as a crime of armed conflict and a crime against humanity.

It is a deeply controversial topic due to its brutality. It has been documented how armed groups have used the bodies of women, men, and children as a tool to inflict fear, punishment, and control. This practice not only physically and emotionally destroys the victims but also has lasting effects on entire communities by generating social destabilization, stigmatization, and the rupture of cultural fabrics. Furthermore, it is an uncomfortable topic for many capacity structures, both state and military, as it implies accepting that these attacks are not simply the "excesses" of individual soldiers, but organized strategies, often authorized by high-ranking commanders.

Opposing positions

Positions on this issue are clearly divided.

The United Nations supports recognition and argues that the use of forced sexual intercourse is a deliberate military tool. They demand international justice, reparations for victims, and more effective prevention mechanisms.

Some governments or military leaders deny responsibility, claiming insufficient evidence or justifying it as an "inevitable side effect." This view is also influenced by political, diplomatic, or cultural interests. They cite a lack of evidence, a cultural context, or difficulties in prosecuting the chain of command. In many cases, investigations are hindered, and

victims are silenced out of fear, shame, or repression. This position tends to present sexual violence as a consequence rather than a strategy.

Why does a debate arise?

The debate arises from the conflict between the recognition of human rights and the reality of impunity in military conflict contexts. Sexual violence as a weapon does not easily fit into the traditional categories of the law of armed conflict, which has led to legal loopholes, a lack of political will to prosecute these crimes, and an enormous debt to the victims due to the lack of justice.

Furthermore, a deeper discussion is underway about gender, capacity, domination, and the armed conflict narratives are constructed. Recognizing these crimes forces us to rethink the role of women in military conflicts, not only as victims, but as political subjects with the right to justice. The lack of access to justice, the social stigmatization of victims, and the use of silence as a political strategy exacerbate the controversy. This debate remains open and is essential to achieving truly comprehensive justice and a lasting peace that does not ignore the sexual dimension of military conflicts.



Objectives

Representing the United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and Empowerment of Women, this chair seeks to protect and strengthen the rights of working women, to eradicate gender aggression, stereotypes, and gender gaps.

This section contains key points that will guide delegates toward finding the most viable solutions to sexual abuse as a method of armed conflict. These objectives cover what solutions are sought and how this problem is to be addressed.

- Examine how and why sexual violence is used to destabilize communities, instill fear, or establish political and territorial control during armed conflicts.
- Recognize that sexual violence in armed conflicts is not accidental, but often organized and tolerated by armed groups.
- Promote the development of laws, judicial mechanisms and public policies that guarantee justice.
- Understand the physical, psychological, social and economic consequences for those affected and their environments.
- Examining specific conflicts to understand patterns of sexual violence in armed conflict.
- Identify the institutional and discursive mechanisms that allow or legitimize the use of sexual violence as an instrument in armed conflict.
- Analyze sexual violence as an extreme manifestation of patriarchal capacity in conflict settings.
- Examining sexual violence as a form of nonverbal warfare communication.



Our goal, as a UN Women, is that at the end of this model, our delegates will come away with many possible solutions to this issue, seeking to eradicate gender inequality.

Therefore, the main idea is to encourage them to use their best skills to reach their full potential and, in doing so, propose revolutionary ideas to improve the situation of women who daily fight against injustices manifested by armed conflicts.

Conclusion

The information presented in this document is intended to arouse the curiosity of our delegates, so that they take the initiative to find out and understand what other women experience on a daily basis, and keep in mind the inequalities that exist in our world.

Sexual violence in armed conflict is not an isolated incident or a collateral consequence, but a strategy used to sow terror, destabilize communities, and exert control. For years, women have been exposed to this abuse without any protection to guarantee their safety. Despite all the challenges, the voices of victims, along with the work of activists, health professionals, and international organizations, have managed to bring this serious problem to light and push countries to take action.

The main objective of this chair is to make this model a unique and memorable experience, starting from discipline and perseverance, following the protocol to the letter, and leaving valuable experiences and learnings to each member of this committee. We, as UN Women, expect the best of our delegates and aspire to act as a great team, with responsibility, dedication, love, and passion.



Thank those who have taken the time to read this document, and we, as Chair, hope that it will be very useful for you to continue expanding your mind and get involved in the constant struggle for the creation of a better world.

Countries

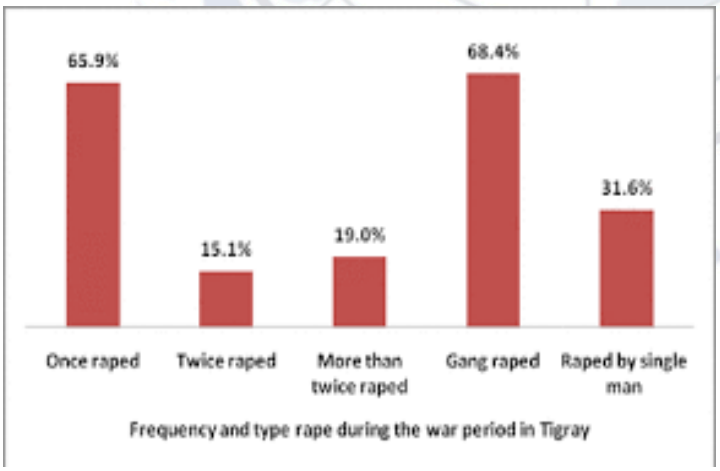
The Democratic Republic of the Congo

The Democratic Republic of the Congo is sadly one of the most emblematic countries for the systematic use of sexual violence, having experienced constant armed conflict since 1997. They use systematic military tactics as a military strategy, not as a random act.

They seek to destroy communities, and there are reports of genital mutilation, the use of weapons during sexual assaults, and even attacks against young children and the elderly. According to the UN, the Democratic Republic of the Congo is one of the countries with the highest prevalence of sexual violence. A 2011 study published in the American Journal of Public Health estimated that more than 1,100 women were sexually assaulted every day in the country at that time.

The Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia

The situation in the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia has been one of the most alarming crises of sexual violence in recent years. Some reports document cases of forced sexual intercourses with objects, genital cutting, and forced injections or pills intended to sterilize women. Soldiers explicitly stated things like, "We want to make sure you don't have Tigrayan children." A joint report by the UN and the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission (EHRC) documented thousands of cases of sexual violence and confirmed that forced sexual assault was used as a weapon to destroy the Tigrayan social fabric.



National investigations have been biased, opaque, or politically manipulated. The Ethiopian government initially denied the allegations, though it later acknowledged some isolated incidents. Despite reports, very few perpetrators have been prosecuted.

The Republic of South Sudan

The Republic of South Sudan has been deeply affected by extremely violent internal conflicts. In these conflicts, sexual violence has been

systematically used as a weapon of armed conflict, both by state forces and rebel groups. Thousands of people were victims of extreme sexual violence; gang forced sexual intercourses were reported, even in the presence of family members, as collective punishment.

According to a report by the UN Commission on Human Rights in South Sudan (2020), tens of thousands of people have been victims of sexual violence since 2013. Most perpetrators have not been brought to justice as the country's judicial system is extremely weak and the perpetrators often belong to armed forces with political protection.

List of Countries

Countries in G5

1. French Republic
2. People's Republic of China
3. Russian Federation
4. United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
5. United States of America

Members of the organization

6. Federative Republic of Brazil (Latin American and Caribbean States Group)
7. Japan (Asia and Pacific States Group)
8. Kingdom of Spain (Western European and Other States Group)
9. The Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (African States Group)
10. Ukraine (Eastern European States Group)

Countries invited to the debate and listening countries:

11. Argentine Republic
12. Canada
13. Federal Republic of Germany
14. Islamic Emirate of Afghanistan
15. Islamic Republic of Iran
16. Islamic Republic of Pakistan
17. Italian Republic
18. Kingdom of Belgium
19. Republic of Colombia
20. Republic of India
21. Socialist Republic of Vietnam
22. State of Israel
23. The Democratic Republic of the Congo
24. The Republic of South Sudan
25. United Mexican States

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"Those who believe in the world are the ones meant to change it."

President: Rocío Haces Sánchez Aedo
Secretary: Mariana Espejel Mateos
Moderator: Ayle Pérez Robles

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